SkillNavora Academy · Master Freelancing

Design and Creative

Fifteen design professions, from principles to client-ready work

Logo · Graphic · Web · Video editing · Photo editing · Photoshop · UX · Presentation · Branding · 3D · UI · Product · Motion · Animation · AI creative

Department 3 of 7 · Draft · Official site: www.skillnavora.in

Tool features and prices change. Official links were not checked live in this draft; confirm before publication.

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How to use this textbook

Design is a skill of seeing and deciding. This textbook teaches the principles, the professional tools and the client process, then the fifteen design professions.

Who it is for

School students (supervised), college students, graduates, working designers, career changers and freelancers.

How design work is judged

Clients judge whether the design solves their problem, reads clearly, works on a phone, and can be used by their team. Originality, craft and process all matter, in that order of importance for the client.

VERIFICATION NOTE

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PART 1 · MODULE A

Design foundations

The principles behind every good design, explained first in simple words.

A1. Colour theory

A colour has three properties: hue (the colour), saturation (how strong) and value (how light). Complementary colours sit opposite on the wheel and create contrast; analogous colours sit side by side and feel calm.

A2. Contrast and accessibility

Text must be readable. The WCAG AA guideline asks for a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text. Check every text colour pair, not only the brand colours.

PYTHON

```
from contrast import contrast_ratio, passes_aa
print(contrast_ratio("#1D1640", "#FFFFFF"))   # 16.92 : passes
print(passes_aa("#9CA3AF", "#FFFFFF"))        # False : too light for body text
```

A3. Typography

Choose one or two typefaces. Keep body text at 16 px or more on screens, with a line height near 1.5. Use a clear scale (for example 14, 16, 20, 28, 40) rather than random sizes.

A4. Composition, alignment, spacing and grids

Align elements to a common edge. Use a spacing scale (8, 16, 24, 32). A 12-column grid on desktop and a 4-column grid on phones keeps layouts consistent.

A5. Visual hierarchy

The viewer should see the most important thing first, then the next, then the detail. Size, weight, colour and space create the order. Test by squinting at the screen: the hierarchy should still read.

A6. Design psychology and visual storytelling

People scan before they read. Faces, arrows and contrast draw attention. A story has a problem, a turn and a result; a good layout guides the eye through the same sequence.

PART 1 · MODULE B

Professional design tools

Twelve tools used across the design professions, with their best use.

Set up each tool with the official guide, make one practice file, and write down what it is best for. Free and paid options change; confirm them on the official page.

Tool	Best for	Free	Paid	Official link (not checked live)
Canva	Quick graphics, presentations, social posts	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com
Figma	Interface and brand design, prototypes, handoff	Free starter plan	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Adobe Photoshop	Photo editing and raster design	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/photoshop.html
Adobe Illustrator	Vector logos and icons	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/illustrator.html
Adobe InDesign	Print layouts, brochures, multi-page documents	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/indesign.html
Adobe Premiere Pro	Video editing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/premiere.html
Adobe After Effects	Motion graphics and compositing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/aftereffects.html
DaVinci Resolve	Video editing and colour	Free version	Paid studio version	www.blackmagicdesign.com/products/davinciresolve
Blender	3D modelling, animation, rendering	Free	Free	www.blender.org
Framer	Design and publish interactive sites	Free tier	Paid plans	www.framer.com
Webflow	No-code websites (see Development and IT)	Free plan	Paid plans	webflow.com
Figma AI features	Generate and edit designs with AI (verify current features)	Check plan	Check plan	www.figma.com

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PART 2 · MODULES C TO E

Logo process, creative projects and design freelancing

How designers work with clients from brief to delivery.

C1. The logo process (14 steps)

1. Client briefing: who, what, why, budget, deadline.
2. Business research: products, values, customers.
3. Competitor analysis: what logos in the category look like.
4. Brand positioning: one sentence on what the brand stands for.
5. Creative direction: three directions, each with a mood and a reason.
6. Concept development: at least eight rough ideas per direction.
7. Sketching: pencil or tablet, fast and many.
8. Typography: choose and adjust the wordmark.
9. Colour selection: a palette of up to three colours, checked for contrast.
10. Digital design: clean vectors in Illustrator or Figma.
11. Mockups: on a sign, a card, a website header and a phone.
12. Client presentation: explain the reasoning, not only the result.
13. Revisions: one or two rounds, agreed in advance.
14. Final file delivery: SVG, PNG, PDF, colour codes and a short usage guide.

C2. Originality

Study competitors to know what to avoid, not to copy. Start from the brand's story and a concept you can explain in a sentence. A logo that could belong to any company is not finished.

D. Creative projects

Brand identity, social graphics, YouTube thumbnails, brochures, websites, mobile interfaces, pitch decks, product advertisements, photo retouching, video editing and 3D modelling. Each project has a brief, a goal, a deadline and a deliverable list.

E. Design freelancing

Topic	What to do
Creative briefs	Write the brief with the client: goal, audience, constraints, examples they like and dislike.
Portfolio	Show the process: problem, research, options, final, result. Use Behance and Dribbble for public work.
Proposals and pricing	State rounds of revisions, the deliverables and the usage rights. Price by project, not by hour alone.
Copyright and licensing	Say who owns the final files, and what the client may use them for, in writing. Check licences for fonts and stock images.
Delivery formats	Deliver vector source files, PNG or JPG for web, PDF for print, and a colour and font guide.

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DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 1

Logo designer

Profession 1 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A logo designer creates the mark and wordmark that identify a business, following a brief, research and a clear concept.

What professionals do every day

Runs client briefings, researches competitors, sketches concepts, builds vector logos, presents options with reasons and delivers the final file package.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Every business needs an identity customers recognise. A good logo is simple, memorable and works at small sizes and in one colour.

- Logos that look like the competition.
- Marks that fail at favicon size or in black and white.
- Brands with no clear reason behind the design.

Skills you need

- Typography and letterform basics.
- Vector drawing in Illustrator or Figma.
- Colour theory and contrast.
- Client briefing and presentation.
- Trademark awareness: check that a mark is not already in use.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Adobe Illustrator	Vector logos	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/illustrator.html
Figma	Vector drawing and presentations	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Inkscape	Open-source vector editor	Free	Free	inkscape.org
Canva	Quick logo templates (less custom)	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Redraw existing simple shapes; learn the pen tool.

Intermediate	Design five logos for fictional businesses from a one-page brief.
Advanced	Build a full identity: primary, icon, one-colour and stacked versions, with usage rules.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Five marks for five fictional cafés.
- **Intermediate:** A wordmark for a tutoring brand.
- **Advanced:** A full identity kit for a fictional clinic.

Client-ready portfolio project

A complete logo identity for a fictional business: research summary, three directions, the final mark in five versions, a colour palette with contrast checks, and a usage guide.

Worked example

Worked example. A bakery brief: a loaf and a whisk merged into one shape. The idea is tested at 32 pixels and in black and white before the colour is chosen.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Brand palette and logo test

Business problem: A fictional bakery needs a palette for its logo and website, checked for accessibility.

Steps

1. Choose three brand colours and a neutral.
2. Check each text pair with the contrast tool.
3. Test the logo at 32 pixels and in one colour.
4. Write a usage note.

Expected output: A palette with pass or fail results and a logo test sheet.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Check every text colour against the background it sits on. The ink-on-white and ink-on-soft pairs pass AA. Brand purple on white scores 5.26:1, so it passes AA for body text. Re-run the check whenever a colour changes.

PYTHON

```
from contrast import contrast_ratio, passes_aa
palette = {"ink": "#1D1640", "brand": "#6C4CF5", "soft": "#F3F0FF", "white": "#FFFFFF"}
text_pairs = [("ink", "white"), ("brand", "white"), ("ink", "soft")]
for fg, bg in text_pairs:
    print(fg, "on", bg, contrast_ratio(palette[fg], palette[bg]), "AA pass:",
passes_aa(palette[fg], palette[bg]))
```

Common mistakes

- Starting in the software before sketching.
- Using a font without checking its licence for commercial use.
- No small-size or one-colour test.
- Presenting one option instead of three.

Freelancing opportunities

- Logo and identity projects for start-ups and small firms.
- Rebrand projects.
- Briefs on freelance marketplaces: 'logo design', 'brand identity'. Present a process-led portfolio.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Adobe Illustrator tutorials
- Figma resource library

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 2

Graphic designer

Profession 2 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A graphic designer creates visual communication: posters, social posts, brochures, packaging and ads, using type, image and colour to carry a message.

What professionals do every day

Turns briefs into layouts, chooses type and imagery, prepares files for print and screen, manages revisions and checks brand rules.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Businesses need consistent, clear visuals in many formats. A graphic designer keeps the brand recognisable and the message easy to read.

- Visuals that are off-brand or hard to read.
- Print files that fail at the printer (colour mode, bleed).
- Campaigns that need many sizes quickly.

Skills you need

- Layout and hierarchy.
- Typography and colour.
- Photo and vector editing.
- File preparation: RGB for screen, CMYK and bleed for print.
- Brief reading and revision management.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Canva	Fast layouts and templates	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com
Adobe InDesign	Multi-page print documents	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/indesign.html
Adobe Photoshop	Image editing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/photoshop.html
GIMP	Open-source image editing	Free	Free	www.gimp.org

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish

Beginner	A social post in three sizes from one layout.
Intermediate	A brochure with a grid and a clear hierarchy.
Advanced	A campaign set with brand rules and print-ready files.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Event poster series.
- **Intermediate:** Product packaging design.
- **Advanced:** Multi-page annual report layout.

Client-ready portfolio project

A campaign of six assets (post, story, banner, poster, flyer, email header) for a fictional shop, built on one layout system with a brand sheet.

Worked example

Worked example. One layout grid, three sizes: the same headline position and the same colour rules, with the text re-flowed for each format.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

A six-asset campaign from one system

Business problem: A shop needs six assets for one campaign, consistent and print-ready.

Steps

1. Build a brand sheet: colours, two typefaces, logo clear space.
2. Design the poster in A3 with 3 mm bleed.
3. Resize the layout for the social and email formats.
4. Export screen files as PNG and print as PDF with crop marks.

Expected output: Six files and a one-page brand sheet.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

One grid and one set of rules produce all six assets. The print PDF carries 3 mm bleed and crop marks; the screen files are RGB. Checking the text against the contrast tool keeps them readable on phones.

Common mistakes

- Mixing RGB and CMYK without a plan.
- Forgetting bleed on print files.
- Too many fonts and colours.
- Text too small to read on a phone.

Freelancing opportunities

- Social and campaign design retainers.
- Print work: flyers, menus, packaging.
- Freelance briefs for 'graphic design', 'social media graphics', 'flyer'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Canva Design School
- Adobe Learn

Web designer

Profession 3 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A web designer plans the look, layout and content of a website so visitors can find information and act. Web design overlaps with web development: the designer decides how the site should look and work; the developer builds it.

What professionals do every day

Plans sitemaps and user journeys, designs page layouts, creates a style system, prepares responsive designs, tests with users and hands over specifications.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

A website is often a business's first impression and main sales tool. A designer makes it clear, fast and easy to use on any device.

- Sites that look good on a laptop and break on a phone.
- Confusing navigation and unclear calls to action.
- Low contrast and small text that exclude readers.

Skills you need

- Information architecture and sitemaps.
- Layout, grids and responsive design.
- Accessible colour and type.
- Prototyping and user testing.
- Basic HTML and CSS to understand what is possible.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Figma	Layout design and prototypes	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Webflow	Design and build websites	Free plan	Paid plans	webflow.com
Framer	Design and publish sites	Free tier	Paid plans	www.framer.com
Maze	User testing	Free tier	Paid plans	maze.co

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Redesign one page of a real or fictional site.
Intermediate	Design a responsive homepage with a sitemap.
Advanced	Run a five-person usability test and fix the top three problems.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Four-page brochure site for a clinic.
- **Intermediate:** Booking flow for a salon.
- **Advanced:** Product catalogue redesign.

Client-ready portfolio project

A complete website design for a fictional local business: sitemap, desktop and phone layouts for three pages, a style guide with contrast checks, and a usability test summary.

Worked example

Worked example. A homepage with one clear action: the 'Book now' button is the only filled, high-contrast element above the fold, and the phone layout places it at the thumb-reach area.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Sitemap and phone layout test

Business problem: A clinic needs a homepage that gets bookings from phones.

Steps

1. Draw a sitemap with five pages.
2. Design the homepage at 390 px and 1280 px.
3. Check that the primary button passes contrast AA.
4. Run a three-person task test: book a visit.

Expected output: Sitemap, two layouts and a test note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The sitemap shows five pages. The phone layout puts the one primary action within thumb reach. The button colour pair is checked with the contrast tool before the design is handed over.

Common mistakes

- Designing for the desktop only.
- Skipping the sitemap, so pages duplicate each other.
- Light grey text that fails contrast.
- No user testing before handover.

Freelancing opportunities

- Website design for small businesses.
- Redesign projects for existing sites.
- Briefs for 'website design', 'UI web design', 'landing page design'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Nielsen Norman Group articles
- WCAG 2.2 quick reference

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 4

Video editor

Profession 4 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A video editor shapes raw footage into a finished piece: cutting, pacing, sound, titles and colour, for ads, films, courses or social media.

What professionals do every day

Reviews footage, builds a rough cut, refines pacing and sound, adds titles and graphics, grades colour, exports for each platform and manages client feedback.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Video is the most used format for marketing and learning. Editors turn long recordings into short, clear, engaging content.

- Long footage that loses the viewer.
- Bad audio and inconsistent colour.
- Exports that fail on the target platform.

Skills you need

- Story structure and pacing.
- Cutting on the beat; J and L cuts.
- Audio levels and music licensing.
- Colour basics.
- File formats and export settings.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
DaVinci Resolve	Editing and colour	Free version	Paid studio	www.blackmagicdesign.com/products/davinciresolve
Adobe Premiere Pro	Professional editing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/premiere.html
CapCut	Short social edits	Free	Paid features	www.capcut.com
Descript	Edit video by editing text	Free tier	Paid plans	www.descript.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish

Beginner	Cut a two-minute interview to one minute.
Intermediate	Edit a 30-second ad with music and titles.
Advanced	Produce a three-part course series with consistent style.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Social reel series for a shop.
- **Intermediate:** Testimonial video.
- **Advanced:** Explainer for a product launch.

Client-ready portfolio project

A 60-second promotional video for a fictional business: rough cut, fine cut, sound mix, titles, colour and three exports (square, vertical, widescreen).

Worked example

Worked example. A 40-second testimonial is cut to 25 seconds by removing pauses and keeping the strongest sentence first, then the title appears on the first frame.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

A 60-second promo in three exports

Business problem: A shop needs one promo video for three platforms.

Steps

1. Cut the footage to 60 seconds with a clear opening.
2. Balance dialogue and music so speech is always clear.
3. Grade the colour for one consistent look.
4. Export square, vertical and widescreen versions.

Expected output: Three exports and a settings note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Speech stays above the music by about 10 dB. The vertical version keeps titles inside the safe area. The settings note records codec, resolution and frame rate for the client's team.

Common mistakes

- Leaving pauses and filler words in.
- Music louder than the voice.
- Titles outside the safe area on phones.
- Exporting without checking the file on a phone.

Freelancing opportunities

- Short-form editing retainers.
- Course and training video editing.
- Briefs for 'video editing', 'reels', 'YouTube editor'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- DaVinci Resolve training (official)
- Adobe Premiere Pro help

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 5

Photo editor

Profession 5 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A photo editor improves and prepares photographs: exposure, colour, retouching, background cleaning and resizing for print or web.

What professionals do every day

Culls shots, adjusts exposure and colour, retouches, removes distractions, keeps colour consistent across a set, and exports to the client's specifications.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Product and portrait photos sell products and people. Clean, consistent images increase trust and conversions.

- Inconsistent colour across a product catalogue.
- Distracting backgrounds and blemishes.
- Files too large for the web or too small for print.

Skills you need

- Exposure, white balance and colour grading.
- Selection and masking.
- Retouching with restraint.
- Export sizes and formats (JPG, PNG, WebP).

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Adobe Lightroom	Batch editing and colour	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/photoshop-lightroom.html
Adobe Photoshop	Retouching and compositing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/photoshop.html
GIMP	Open-source retouching	Free	Free	www.gimp.org
Snapseed	Phone editing	Free	Free	snapseed.online

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Correct exposure and white balance on ten product photos.
Intermediate	Remove a background cleanly.

Advanced	Batch-edit a catalogue of 50 items with one preset.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Catalogue of 50 products.
- **Intermediate:** Portrait retouching with a natural look.
- **Advanced:** Real estate photo set.

Client-ready portfolio project

A 20-photo product set for a fictional shop: consistent colour, backgrounds cleaned, and web and print exports with a checklist.

Worked example

Worked example. A white mug photographed under warm light is corrected by setting the white balance from a grey card in the shot, then matching the whole set with one preset.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Consistent 20-photo product set

Business problem: A shop needs 20 product photos with one look.

Steps

1. Set white balance and exposure on the first image.
2. Create a preset and apply it to the set.
3. Check each image against the colour reference.
4. Export web (2000 px, sRGB) and print (300 dpi) versions.

Expected output: A set of images and an export log.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

One reference shot sets the colour; the preset keeps the set consistent. Web exports use sRGB so colours match across screens.

Common mistakes

- Over-smoothing skin or product textures.
- Editing on an uncalibrated screen.
- Forgetting to check colour profiles on export.
- No backup of originals.

Freelancing opportunities

- Product photo editing for online shops.

- Real estate and event photo sets.
- Briefs for 'photo editing', 'retouching', 'product photos'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Adobe Lightroom help

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 6

Photoshop expert

Profession 6 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A Photoshop expert uses Adobe Photoshop at a high level: complex compositing, retouching, mockups, automation with actions and templates, and print preparation.

What professionals do every day

Builds layered compositions, creates reusable templates and actions, delivers mockups, prepares print files and trains teams on the software.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Agencies and brands need reliable, fast production. An expert builds templates and actions that save hours on every project.

- Repetitive tasks done by hand.
- Mockups that look fake.
- Files that are hard for others to edit.

Skills you need

- Layers, masks, smart objects and blend modes.
- Selection and retouching techniques.
- Actions and templates.
- Print preparation: CMYK, bleed, resolution.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Adobe Photoshop	Professional image editing	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/photoshop.html
Photopea	Browser-based editor that reads PSD files	Free with ads	Paid removal of ads	www.photopea.com
Adobe Photoshop tutorials	Official learning	Free	Free	helpx.adobe.com/photoshop.html

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Build a layered poster with masks.
Intermediate	Create a product mockup with a smart object.
Advanced	Record an action that resizes a set of files.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Mockup pack for a product line.
- **Intermediate:** Social template system.
- **Advanced:** Print-ready event poster.

Client-ready portfolio project

A reusable mockup template and an action set for a fictional brand, with a layer-naming guide so another designer can edit the file.

Worked example

Worked example. A smart object holds the client's screenshot. Replacing the image updates every mockup at once; the file keeps the layers named and grouped.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Template with smart objects and an action

Business problem: A brand wants mockups it can update without a designer.

Steps

1. Build the mockup with a smart object for the screen.
2. Name and group every layer.
3. Record an action that exports three sizes.
4. Test by replacing the screen image.

Expected output: A template, an action and a short editing guide.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The smart object keeps the replacement non-destructive. Named layers and groups make the file usable by others. The action removes the repetitive export step.

Common mistakes

- Destroying originals by editing pixels directly.
- Unnamed layers that nobody can follow.
- Mockups with lighting that does not match the scene.
- Giving clients unlocked files with no guide.

Freelancing opportunities

- Template and mockup systems for brands.
- Print and packaging preparation.
- Briefs for 'Photoshop', 'mockup', 'photo compositing'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Adobe Photoshop help and tutorials

UX designer

Profession 7 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A UX designer shapes how a product works for its users: research, journeys, flows, usability and testing. UX is about the whole experience, not the look alone.

What professionals do every day

Interviews users, maps journeys, writes problem statements, designs flows and prototypes, tests with users, measures results and works with product and engineering teams.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Products fail when users cannot finish their task. UX designers find where people get stuck and fix it before engineers build the wrong thing.

- Users who drop off in the middle of a task.
- Features nobody understands.
- Expensive rebuilds caused by late discovery.

Skills you need

- User research: interviews and surveys.
- Journey mapping and problem statements.
- Information architecture and flows.
- Usability testing and metrics.
- Accessibility basics.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Figma	Prototypes and flows	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Maze	Remote usability tests	Free tier	Paid plans	maze.co
Miro	Journey maps and workshops	Free tier	Paid plans	miro.com
Nielsen Norman Group	Research articles	Free articles	Paid courses	www.nngroup.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Interview five users and summarise pain points.
Intermediate	Map one journey and find three drop-off points.

Advanced	Test a prototype with five users and fix the top problem.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Booking flow redesign.
- **Intermediate:** Onboarding for a learning app.
- **Advanced:** Checkout usability study.

Client-ready portfolio project

A UX case study for a fictional clinic's booking flow: research summary, journey map, a redesigned flow, a prototype and a five-person test with results.

Worked example

Worked example. Five of five users stopped at the date picker. The fix is a clearer date control with the next available slots shown first; the retest finished the task with no help.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Usability test and fix

Business problem: A clinic's booking flow loses users at the date step.

Steps

1. Recruit five users matching the patient profile.
2. Give each a task: book a visit for next week.
3. Record where each user stops or hesitates.
4. Redesign the top issue and retest with five new users.

Expected output: A test summary with before and after completion counts.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Completion rises only when the fix addresses the observed problem. Keep the test script identical so the comparison is fair. Report counts, not impressions.

Common mistakes

- Testing with colleagues instead of real users.
- Asking leading questions.
- Making changes without the evidence from testing.
- Ignoring accessibility.

Freelancing opportunities

- UX research and redesign projects.

- Prototype and usability testing services.
- Briefs for 'UX design', 'usability testing', 'prototype'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Nielsen Norman Group articles
- Interaction Design Foundation (check current free and paid content)

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 8

Presentation designer

Profession 8 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A presentation designer turns content into slides that persuade and explain: decks for pitches, sales, training and board reports.

What professionals do every day

Structures the story, designs slide layouts and charts, sets a template, checks readability on screen, and fixes slides after feedback.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

A clear deck wins meetings and funding. Designers make complex information easy to follow in the time a presenter has.

- Slides with too much text.
- Charts that mislead or are hard to read.
- Decks that do not match the brand.

Skills you need

- Storytelling and slide structure.
- Hierarchy, grids and readable type.
- Chart design and data honesty.
- PowerPoint, Google Slides and Keynote skills.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Microsoft PowerPoint	Standard presentations	Free online version	Microsoft 365 plans	www.microsoft.com/microsoft-365/powerpoint
Google Slides	Shared decks	Free	Paid Workspace plans	slides.google.com
Canva	Templates for quick decks	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com
Pitch	Collaborative decks	Free tier	Paid plans	pitch.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Rebuild a 10-slide deck with one message per slide.
Intermediate	Design a chart that shows one comparison clearly.

Advanced	Create a template with five layouts and a brand sheet.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Investor pitch deck.
- **Intermediate:** Sales deck for a service.
- **Advanced:** Training deck with exercises.

Client-ready portfolio project

A 10-slide pitch deck for a fictional edtech company: story, three charts, a template and speaker notes.

Worked example

Worked example. A slide reading 'Revenue grew 40%' gets one chart with the two bars labelled and a one-line takeaway; the rest of the detail goes to the notes.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Chart that tells one story

Business problem: A deck needs a chart comparing two years of enrolments.

Steps

1. Choose a bar chart with two bars.
2. Label the axis and the values.
3. Write a takeaway in the title.
4. Check the axis starts at zero.

Expected output: One slide and a note on the choice.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Bars show the comparison directly. The axis starts at zero so the difference is not exaggerated. The title states the conclusion, and the notes hold the detail.

Common mistakes

- Reading the slides aloud.
- Too many fonts or colours.
- Charts with truncated axes that exaggerate change.
- Ignoring the presenter's time limit.

Freelancing opportunities

- Pitch and sales decks for start-ups.
- Training decks for teams.

- Briefs for 'presentation design', 'pitch deck', 'PowerPoint'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Microsoft PowerPoint help
- Canva design school

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 9

Branding designer

Profession 9 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A branding designer builds the whole identity of a business: name, logo, colour, type, voice and the rules that keep every touchpoint consistent.

What professionals do every day

Researches the market and brand, defines personality and positioning, creates the identity system, writes the brand guide and supports rollout.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Consistent branding builds trust and recognition. A brand system lets the business grow without each new asset becoming a new design project.

- Inconsistent logos and colours across channels.
- Brands that do not stand out.
- Guidelines that nobody can follow.

Skills you need

- Brand strategy and positioning.
- Logo systems and typography.
- Colour systems with contrast checks.
- Brand guidelines writing.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Figma	Brand systems and guides	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Adobe Illustrator	Logos and icons	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/illustrator.html
Frontify	Brand guideline platform	Trial	Paid plans	www.frontify.com
Coolors	Palette generator	Free	Paid plans	coolors.co

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Define a palette with contrast checks.
Intermediate	Write a one-page brand voice sheet.

Advanced	Build a mini brand guide with logo rules.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Identity for a café.
- **Intermediate:** Brand system for an education company.
- **Advanced:** Rebrand of a local clinic.

Client-ready portfolio project

A complete brand system for a fictional clinic: positioning, logo, palette with contrast checks, type scale, voice sheet and an eight-page guide.

Worked example

Worked example. A clinic's positioning is 'calm, precise, local'. Each choice follows from that: soft colours, a plain sans-serif, short sentences in the voice sheet.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Palette with accessibility checks

Business problem: A clinic brand needs a palette that works on screens and passes contrast checks.

Steps

1. Pick a primary colour, a dark text colour and a soft background.
2. Check each text pair with the contrast checker (see the Design foundations).
3. Adjust any pair that fails until it passes AA.
4. Record the final values in the guide.

Expected output: A palette, a pass table and a brand guide page.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The checker shows which pairs pass. Any failing pair is adjusted rather than used with a note to 'be careful'. The final palette is recorded with hex values and the passing ratios.

Common mistakes

- Choosing trendy colours that fail accessibility.
- Guides with no examples.
- Logo rules missing for small sizes.
- Rollout without training the team.

Freelancing opportunities

- Brand identity packages for start-ups.
- Brand guide design and rollout support.
- Briefs for 'brand identity', 'branding', 'brand guidelines'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Frontify brand guide resources

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 10

3D modeller

Profession 10 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A 3D modeller creates three-dimensional objects and scenes for product visualisation, animation, games, architecture and advertising.

What professionals do every day

Models objects from briefs and reference, sets materials and lighting, renders images, checks scale and topology, and exports for the client's pipeline.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Products can be shown before they exist, from every angle, in any colour. 3D reduces photo shoots and speeds approvals.

- Objects with wrong scale or messy geometry.
- Renders with poor lighting that do not look real.
- Files that cannot be used in the client's software.

Skills you need

- Modelling basics: vertices, edges, faces.
- Materials, textures and UV mapping.
- Lighting and rendering.
- File formats (glTF, OBJ, FBX).

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Blender	3D modelling, animation and rendering	Free	Free	www.blender.org
Blender manual	Official reference	Free	Free	docs.blender.org/manual/en/latest/
SketchUp	Architecture and product modelling	Free web version	Paid plans	www.sketchup.com
Sketchfab	Share and view 3D models	Free tier	Paid plans	sketchfab.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Model a simple product (a mug) to correct scale.
Intermediate	Texture it and light it for a product image.

Advanced	Export a glTF file and check it in a viewer.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Product visualisation for a shop.
- **Intermediate:** Architectural interior render.
- **Advanced:** Animated product spin.

Client-ready portfolio project

A product visualisation for a fictional bottle brand: model to scale, materials, lighting, three render views and a glTF export with a file note.

Worked example

Worked example. A 500 ml bottle is modelled at 500 ml scale, so the render matches the real product in the client's catalogue.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Scaled model and export

Business problem: A brand needs a bottle model for its catalogue at true scale.

Steps

1. Model the bottle using the given dimensions.
2. Apply a glass material and a label texture.
3. Light with a three-point setup and render three views.
4. Export glTF and check it opens in a web viewer.

Expected output: Renders, a glTF file and a note on units and scale.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Units are set at the start so dimensions are true. The glTF export carries the materials; the viewer check confirms the file works outside Blender.

Common mistakes

- Ignoring scale until the end.
- Overly dense meshes that slow the viewer.
- Exporting without checking textures.
- Lighting that is too flat.

Freelancing opportunities

- Product renders for online shops.

- Interior and architectural visualisation.
- Briefs for 'Blender', '3D product model', '3D rendering'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Blender manual (official)
- Blender tutorials (official)

UI designer

Profession 11 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A UI designer designs the screens and components of a digital product: buttons, forms, navigation, layouts and states, in a system the team can reuse.

What professionals do every day

Designs screens from flows, builds a component library with states, applies the style system, checks accessibility and prepares handoff for developers.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Good interfaces make tasks obvious. A component system keeps the product consistent and speeds the team up.

- Inconsistent buttons and forms across screens.
- Missing states (error, empty, loading).
- Handoffs that developers must guess.

Skills you need

- Layout, spacing and typography for screens.
- Components, variants and states.
- Accessibility: contrast, focus, touch targets.
- Design tokens and handoff.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Figma	Component libraries and prototypes	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Storybook	Documenting components for developers	Free	Free	storybook.js.org
Material Design guidelines	Design reference from Google	Free	Free	m3.material.io
Apple Human Interface Guidelines	Platform reference	Free	Free	developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Design a login screen with all states.

Intermediate	Build a button component with four variants.
Advanced	Create a settings screen using the component library.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Dashboard UI for a SaaS.
- **Intermediate:** Booking app screens.
- **Advanced:** Checkout flow components.

Client-ready portfolio project

A component library of 12 components with states, and a three-screen app flow using them, with handoff notes for developers.

Worked example

Worked example. The primary button has default, hover, focus, pressed and disabled states; focus has a visible outline, and the text pair passes contrast.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Component states and contrast

Business problem: A product team needs a button that is consistent and accessible.

Steps

1. Design the button with five states.
2. Check the text on each background pair with the contrast checker.
3. Add a visible focus outline.
4. Write the handoff note with token names.

Expected output: The component in five states and a handoff note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Each state is designed and named. The focus outline is required for keyboard users. Token names let developers match the design to the code.

Common mistakes

- Designing only the default state.
- Using colour alone to show status.
- Tiny touch targets on phones.
- No handoff notes.

Freelancing opportunities

- UI design for SaaS and app start-ups.
- Component library projects for product teams.
- Briefs for 'UI design', 'dashboard design', 'Figma design system'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Material Design 3 (official guidelines)
- WCAG 2.2 quick reference

Product designer

Profession 12 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A product designer owns the design of a product from problem to launch, working with product managers and engineers on research, interaction design and the interface.

What professionals do every day

Frames problems with the team, researches users, prototypes solutions, tests them, designs the interface and measures outcomes after launch.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Teams need someone who connects user needs, business goals and technical limits. A product designer makes that connection visible.

- Features built without evidence of user need.
- Interfaces that do not match the business goal.
- Slow decisions because options are not tested.

Skills you need

- Problem framing and research.
- Interaction design and prototyping.
- Testing and metrics (see Module A of the Marketing department for metrics).
- Collaboration with engineers.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Figma	Prototypes and design files	Free starter	Paid plans	www.figma.com
Maze	Testing with users	Free tier	Paid plans	maze.co
Amplitude	Product analytics (verify plans)	Free tier	Paid plans	amplitude.com
Miro	Workshops and maps	Free tier	Paid plans	miro.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Run one prototype test and write a findings summary.
Intermediate	Design one feature end to end with a success metric.
Advanced	Lead a design critique with a checklist.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Onboarding redesign for a learning app.
- **Intermediate:** Pricing page experiment.
- **Advanced:** Feature design for a booking product.

Client-ready portfolio project

A product design case study for a fictional app: problem, research, three solutions tested, the chosen design, a success metric and the post-launch plan.

Worked example

Worked example. Users abandon onboarding at step three. Two prototypes are tested; the shorter version finishes faster and is chosen, with completion rate as the success metric.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Test two prototypes and choose

Business problem: A team cannot decide between two onboarding designs.

Steps

1. Build two low-fidelity prototypes.
2. Test each with five users on the same tasks.
3. Compare completion and time.
4. Choose one and define a success metric.

Expected output: A comparison table and the decision with reasons.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

A fair test uses the same tasks and the same users type. Completion and time are compared directly. The decision is written with the metric that will show whether it worked.

Common mistakes

- Testing with the design team.
- Choosing by preference rather than evidence.
- No success metric.
- Ignoring the engineering cost of a design.

Freelancing opportunities

- Product design for start-ups.
- Fractional design leadership for product teams.
- Briefs for 'product design', 'UX case study', 'prototype testing'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Nielsen Norman Group articles

Motion graphics designer

Profession 13 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A motion graphics designer adds movement to graphics and text: titles, explainers, animated logos, social ads and interface motion.

What professionals do every day

Animates titles and icons, plans timing and easing, designs transitions, exports for each platform and maintains reusable templates.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Motion draws attention and explains things quickly. Brands use it in ads, social content and product explainers.

- Motion that is distracting or too slow.
- Animations that do not export well.
- Motion that breaks on mobile performance.

Skills you need

- Timing, easing and keyframes.
- Layering and shapes.
- Typography in motion.
- Export settings for web and video.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Adobe After Effects	Motion graphics	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/aftereffects.html
Rive	Interactive animations for apps and web	Free tier	Paid plans	rive.app
Lottie	Animations on the web and apps (open format)	Free	Free	lottiefiles.com
Canva	Simple animated graphics	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Animate a logo reveal in five seconds.

Intermediate	Make a title sequence with three text styles.
Advanced	Create a looping social graphic under 2 MB.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Animated logo for a brand.
- **Intermediate:** Explainer intro for a course.
- **Advanced:** Product feature highlights.

Client-ready portfolio project

A 15-second explainer motion piece for a fictional app: storyboard, animated title, icons, export in video and a lightweight loop for the web.

Worked example

Worked example. A title rises with ease-out timing over 0.4 seconds, then the subtitle follows 0.2 seconds later: a small stagger that guides the eye.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Logo reveal under 5 seconds

Business problem: A brand wants a short animated logo for video and the web.

Steps

1. Storyboard three beats.
2. Animate the logo mark and wordmark with easing.
3. Export video (MP4) and a lightweight loop (Lottie or GIF).
4. Check file size and playback on a phone.

Expected output: Two files and a settings note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The web loop is kept small so it loads quickly. Easing gives a natural feel; the stagger guides attention from mark to name.

Common mistakes

- Animating everything at once.
- Ignoring file size for the web.
- No accessibility option for reduced motion.
- Long animations that the viewer must wait for.

Freelancing opportunities

- Animated ads and social series.
- Explainers for software companies.
- Briefs for 'motion graphics', 'animated logo', 'explainer video'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Adobe After Effects help
- Rive documentation

Animation specialist

Profession 14 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

An animation specialist creates characters and scenes that move: 2D or 3D animation for films, ads, games, education and product explainers.

What professionals do every day

Plans shots and performance, animates characters, checks timing and weight, works with designers and sound, and delivers render-ready files.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Animated stories and characters hold attention for long periods, which suits education and brand storytelling.

- Motion that looks stiff or floaty.
- Scenes that are hard to revise late in production.
- Render times that blow the schedule.

Skills you need

- Principles of animation: timing, spacing, weight.
- Character rigs (3D) or frame-by-frame drawing (2D).
- Storyboarding and shot planning.
- Export and render management.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Blender	3D animation and rendering	Free	Free	www.blender.org
Toon Boom Harmony	2D animation	Trial	Paid plans	www.toonboom.com
Krita	Open-source drawing for frames	Free	Free	krita.org
Adobe Animate	2D animation and interactive files	Trial	Subscription	www.adobe.com/products/animate.html

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Animate a bouncing ball with timing and squash.
Intermediate	Animate a three-frame walk cycle.

Advanced	Storyboard and animate a 20-second scene.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Explainer character for a course.
- **Intermediate:** Short ad with a mascot.
- **Advanced:** Animated scene for a product launch.

Client-ready portfolio project

A 20-second animated explainer with one character: storyboard, key poses, timing sheet, a rendered video and a short revision log.

Worked example

Worked example. A character jumps: anticipation (crouch), the jump, a squash on landing, then settle. Each stage gets frames on a timing sheet.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Bouncing ball and walk cycle

Business problem: A student needs to learn timing before character work.

Steps

1. Animate a ball that bounces three times with squash.
2. Animate a three-frame walk cycle.
3. Review timing on a playback at 12 and 24 frames per second.
4. Document the timing choices.

Expected output: Two short animations and a timing note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Squash and stretch show weight. The walk cycle repeats cleanly if the first and last poses match. The timing note records why each frame count was chosen.

Common mistakes

- Animating without a storyboard.
- Ignoring weight and timing.
- Revising late without a shot list.
- Rendering at the wrong frame rate.

Freelancing opportunities

- Explainer animation for education and software companies.

- Short ads with characters.
- Briefs for '2D animation', '3D animation', 'explainer animation'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Blender manual (official)

DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 15

AI creative specialist

Profession 15 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

An AI creative specialist uses generative tools in creative work: concept generation, image and video drafts, voice, and the review and rights checks that make the output usable for a client.

What professionals do every day

Writes creative briefs, generates concepts and drafts with image, video and voice tools, selects and refines the best outputs, checks rights and brand fit, and documents the process.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Clients want faster concepts and more variations. A specialist who can generate, select and check AI output saves time without losing quality or rights clarity.

- Generated images that break brand or copyright rules.
- Concepts that look generic.
- Client files with unclear ownership.

Skills you need

- Creative briefs and prompt writing.
- Image and video generation tools.
- Selection, retouching and brand fit.
- Rights, licensing and disclosure of AI-generated content.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Adobe Firefly	Image generation within Adobe tools (verify terms)	Check plan	Check plan	www.adobe.com/products/firefly.html
Midjourney	Image generation	Check plan	Paid subscription	www.midjourney.com
Canva	Templates and AI features	Free	Paid plans	www.canva.com
ElevenLabs	Voice generation (verify rights)	Free tier	Paid plans	elevenlabs.io

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Generate 20 concepts from one brief and select five.
Intermediate	Write a prompt log for a campaign.

Advanced	Produce a brand-safe image set with a rights note.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Campaign concept set.
- **Intermediate:** Product mood boards.
- **Advanced:** Voice and visual pack for a course.

Client-ready portfolio project

A campaign concept pack for a fictional brand: brief, 20 generated concepts, a shortlist of five with reasons, a prompt log, a rights and disclosure note.

Worked example

Worked example. The brief asks for 'warm, calm, local' imagery. Twenty drafts are generated; five are chosen because they match the brand palette and avoid recognisable people or logos.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Campaign concept pack with a rights note

Business problem: A brand needs campaign concepts quickly and a clear record of how they were made.

Steps

1. Write a one-page brief with mood, palette and forbidden elements.
2. Generate 20 concepts, logging the prompt and settings for each.
3. Shortlist five using the brief as the checklist.
4. Write a rights and disclosure note: tool terms, third-party elements, labelling.

Expected output: A pack with the brief, prompt log, shortlist and rights note.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The shortlist is judged against the brief, not personal taste. The prompt log makes the work reproducible. The rights note records what the tool's terms allow and what the client must disclose.

Common mistakes

- Using generated work without checking tool terms.
- Generated people or logos that imitate real ones.
- No prompt log, so the work cannot be reproduced.
- Presenting raw outputs as finished design.

Freelancing opportunities

- Concept packs and mood boards for brands.
- AI-assisted campaign production (with a human design review).
- Briefs for 'AI image', 'AI creative', 'concept design'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Canva design school
- Adobe Firefly help (verify current terms)